turn topsy-turvy biologists' ideas of relations between rivals of the same sex, between parents and offspring, between enemies of different species. I find the prospect rather worrying, because it means that theories of almost limitless craziness can no longer be ruled out on commonsense grounds. If we observe an animal doing something really silly, like standing on its head instead of running away from a lion, it may be doing it in order to show off to a female. It may even be showing off to the lion: 'I am such a high-quality animal you would be wasting your time trying to catch me' (see p. 222).

But, no matter how crazy I think something is, natural selection may have other ideas. An animal will turn back-somersaults in front of a slavering pack of predators if the risks enhance the advertisement more than they endanger the advertiser. It is its very dangerousness that gives the gesture showing-off power. Of course, natural selection won't favour infinite danger. At the point where exhibitionism becomes downright foolhardy, it will be penalized. A risky or costly performance may look crazy to us. But it really isn't any of our business. Natural selection alone is entitled to judge.